

Data Insight Report: Global E-Commerce Consumer Behavior Trends 2024–2025

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1. Executive Summary

This report examines how e-commerce consumer behavior diverged across four major regions between 2024 and 2025, and argues that the headline story of "global e-commerce growth" conceals four structurally different markets that require materially different merchant strategies.

The central finding is that mobile commerce has crossed from a growth channel to the default entry point, while social commerce has quietly become the dominant discovery surface. Mobile devices accounted for an estimated 57% of global e-commerce sales in 2024, projected to reach 59% in 2025 [1]. Separately, 46% of consumers now purchase products directly through social media — up from 21% in 2019, a 119% increase in five years [2].

Second, the "green premium" is smaller and more conditional than survey headlines suggest. While 80% of consumers claim willingness to pay more for sustainable goods, the average stated premium is only 9.7% — and the same survey records that 31% of consumers name inflation as their number-one risk [2]. The gap between stated intention and revealed behaviour is where most sustainability marketing currently fails.

Third, returns have become a structural cost rather than an operational nuisance. The National Retail Federation projects total US retail returns of \$849.9 billion in 2025, with 19.3% of online sales returned — materially above the all-channel rate of 15.8% [3]. For merchants, returns now represent a margin decision, not a customer-service decision.

Fourth, the fastest-growing region is not the one most often discussed. Latin American retail e-commerce is projected to grow 12.2% in 2025 to \$191.25 billion, which eMarketer describes as making it the fastest-growing region worldwide [4], while Southeast Asian platform GMV grew 12% to \$128.4 billion with live and video commerce now accounting for 20% of platform GMV [5].

Headline metric (2024–2025)	Value	Source
Mobile share of global e-commerce sales, 2024	57% (est. 59% in 2025)	Red Stag Fulfillment [1]
Consumers buying directly through social media	46%, up from 21% in 2019	PwC [2]
Consumers willing to pay more for sustainable goods	80%, at an average 9.7% premium	PwC [2]
US online return rate, 2025	19.3% of online sales	NRF / Happy Returns [3]
Total US retail returns, 2025	\$849.9 billion	NRF / Happy Returns [3]
Latin America retail e-commerce, 2025	\$191.25 bn, +12.2% YoY	eMarketer [4]
Southeast Asia platform e-commerce GMV, 2024	\$128.4 bn, +12% YoY	Momentum Works [5]
Southeast Asia live + video commerce share, 2024	20% of platform GMV	Momentum Works [5]
US BNPL loan originations, 2023	335.8 m loans, \$45.2 bn	CFPB [6]

2. Methodology

2.1 Approach

This report synthesises publicly available datasets, survey results and industry research covering 2024–2025 e-commerce consumer behaviour across four regions. Sources were selected to span three categories: government and regulatory publications (CFPB, NRF), large-sample academic-adjacent surveys (PwC Voice of the Consumer, Simon-Kucher Global Sustainability Study), and specialist e-commerce research houses with published regional breakdowns (eMarketer, Momentum Works, Oberlo).

2.2 Source hierarchy and why it matters

The reliability of e-commerce data varies sharply by source type, and a report that does not disclose this hierarchy is not usable for commercial decisions. This report applies the following ordering:

- **Highest weight: government and regulatory data.** The CFPB's BNPL Market Report draws on de-identified aggregate data from six large lenders (Affirm, Cash App Afterpay, Klarna, PayPal, Sezzle, Zip) representing an estimated 40% of the US point-of-sale financing market [6]. The NRF/Happy Returns Landscape is a joint industry survey [3]. Both are primary, methodologically disclosed, and refreshable.
- **High weight: large-sample surveys with disclosed methodology.** The PwC 2024 Voice of the Consumer Survey polled over 20,000 consumers across 31 countries [2]; the Simon-Kucher 2024 Global Sustainability Study surveyed 6,120 consumers across six countries [7]. Sample size and geographic coverage are disclosed, which permits appropriate regional reading.
- **Medium weight: specialist research houses.** eMarketer, Momentum Works, Oberlo and e-Conomy SEA publish regional GMV and channel-share data derived from proprietary modelling. These are the best available for regional sizing but are not independently auditable, and their scope definitions differ.

Reconciliation note. Figures for "global e-commerce size" vary by an order of magnitude across sources, because vendors define scope differently: some count only platform marketplace GMV, others include brand-direct and social channels, others include travel and food delivery. This report does not aggregate these into a single global number. Where a figure is quoted, its scope and source are stated inline, and comparisons are only drawn between figures of matching scope.

2.3 Currency and periodisation

Data is reported on the basis published by each source. Where sources use different calendar periods (for example CFPB BNPL data covering calendar years 2019–2023, versus eMarketer 2025 retail forecasts), the period is stated explicitly. CFPB dollar figures are inflation-adjusted using the BLS CPI-U with 2024 as the reference year [6].

3. Mobile Commerce: The Default Channel

3.1 What the data shows

Mobile devices accounted for approximately **57% of global e-commerce sales in 2024**, with an estimate of **59% in 2025** [1]. Global mobile e-commerce sales surpassed \$2.2 trillion in 2024 [8], and are projected to exceed \$3 trillion by 2027 [9]. Growth is moderating from hyper-growth to a mature 9–11% annual range during 2026–2028 [9].

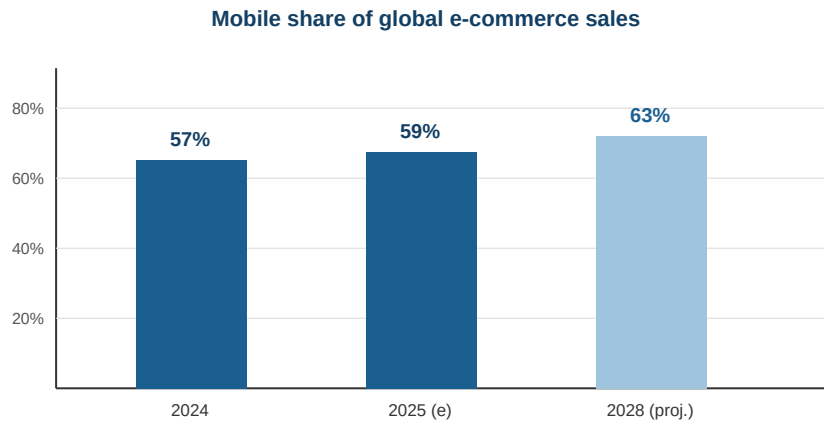


Figure 1. Mobile share of global e-commerce sales, 2024–2028. Sources: 2024/2025 actuals from Red Stag Fulfillment citing industry data [1]; 2028 projection from DemandSage [10]. 2025 and 2028 bars are estimates/projections, not reported actuals.

3.2 Interpretation: the channel is no longer a differentiator

The commercially important shift is not that mobile is growing, but that mobile has become the *default* and therefore ceased to be a differentiator. When 57% of transactions originate on a phone, a mobile-first experience is table stakes rather than a competitive advantage. The corollary is that the remaining differentiation has moved upstream and downstream: upstream into discovery (where social commerce now competes) and downstream into fulfilment, returns and payment.

The moderation of growth from hyper-growth to 9–11% annual rates during 2026–2028 [9] reinforces this reading. The channel is now the default, and incremental advantage must come from conversion efficiency on that channel rather than from migrating traffic onto it.

4. Social Commerce: From Discovery to Checkout

4.1 What the data shows

Social commerce is the fastest-scaling channel in the dataset. Oberlo's series places global social commerce sales at \$699.4 billion in 2024, growing 22.6% year-over-year, and projects sales to exceed **\$1 trillion by 2028** [11]. Social commerce represented an estimated 19.4% of global e-commerce sales in 2024, forecast to reach 21.7% by 2028 [11].

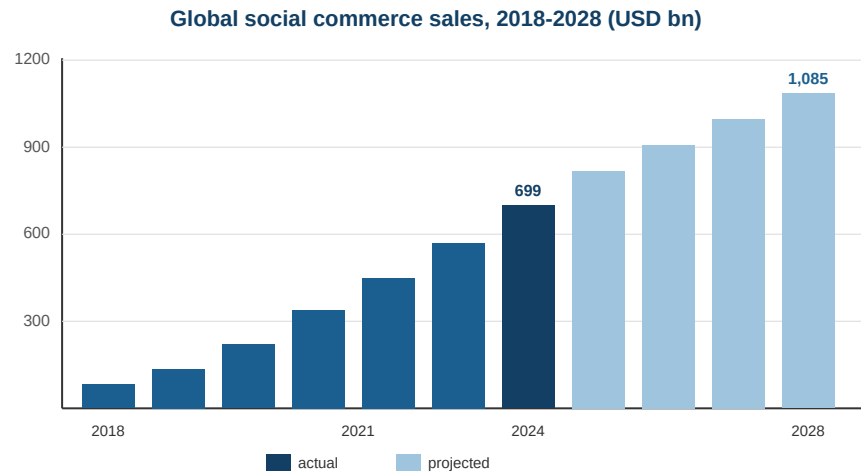


Figure 2. Global social commerce sales 2018–2028. Source: Oberlo [11]. Bars 2025–2028 are Oberlo projections, not reported actuals. Annual growth decelerates from 67.0% (2019) to 8.8% (2028) while absolute sales increase 13.3×.

Two further findings sharpen the picture. First, PwC's 2024 survey records that **46% of consumers purchased products directly through social media, up from 21% in 2019** [2]. Second, US social commerce sales reached \$71.62 billion in 2024, up 26% year over year, while TikTok Shop's global GMV reached \$33.2 billion in 2024, up 201% from 2023 [12].

4.2 Interpretation: discovery and transaction have merged

The 119% increase in direct social purchasing between 2019 and 2024 [2] is the single most consequential consumer-behaviour change in this dataset, and its commercial meaning is often understated. The conventional e-commerce funnel separates discovery (search, advertising, social) from transaction (marketplace, brand site, app). Social commerce collapses that separation: the platform where a consumer discovers a product is increasingly the platform where the purchase is completed.

The consequence for merchants is a loss of an optimisation surface. A merchant that previously controlled its own product page, checkout flow and post-purchase relationship now frequently loses the transaction itself to the platform. The offsetting opportunity is that the collapsed funnel also collapses attribution, making the highest-intent traffic the hardest to measure and defend.

5. Sustainability-Driven Purchasing

5.1 What the data shows

The PwC 2024 Voice of the Consumer Survey, covering more than 20,000 consumers across 31 countries, establishes the current baseline [2]:

- **80% of consumers are willing to pay more** for sustainably produced or sourced goods.
- **The average stated premium is 9.7%** — materially below the level most marketing claims imply.
- **46% report buying more sustainable products** to reduce environmental impact.
- **85% report experiencing first-hand the disruptive effects of climate change** in their daily lives.
- **But 31% cite inflation as the number-one risk** to their country or territory, and 62% expect groceries to be their largest spending increase.

PwC's own framing is the analytically important part: willingness to pay "may not translate into actual spend due to factors including inflation, macroeconomic volatility, and cost-of-living concerns" [2].

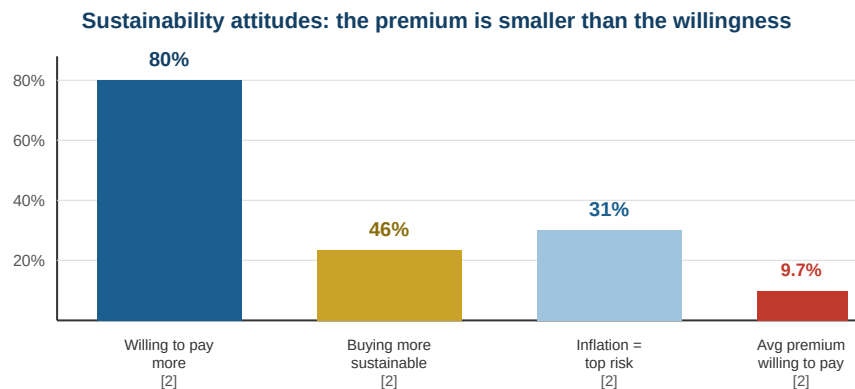


Figure 3. Sustainability attitudes, PwC 2024 Voice of the Consumer Survey (n>20,000, 31 countries). The 9.7% average premium (red) is shown against willingness-to-pay percentages for scale; it is a mean premium among willing consumers, not a share. Source: PwC [2].

5.2 Interpretation: stated willingness is not revealed behaviour

The most commercially useful number in this section is the smallest one. An average stated premium of 9.7% [2] is below the margin at which most merchants can price a genuinely sustainable product line and still compete on conventional unit economics. A merchant who prices a sustainable line at a 20–30% premium is not addressing the population the 9.7% figure describes; they are addressing a much smaller, more committed segment.

The survey's disclosure that 31% of consumers name inflation as their number-one risk [2] explains the attrition between willingness and purchase: sustainability competes directly with grocery inflation for discretionary spend, and inflation wins the budget. The commercially robust sustainability propositions are therefore the ones that avoid a price premium entirely — efficiency, durability, reduced waste, lower total cost of ownership — rather than those that require one.

6. Payment Method Shifts

6.1 What the data shows

The US buy-now-pay-later (BNPL) market provides the most methodologically transparent dataset available, sourced from six large lenders and published by the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau [6]:

BNPL metric (inflation-adjusted)	2019	2021	2022	2023
Loan originations (millions)	19.8	196.6	273.8	335.8
Dollar originations (USD bn)	\$2.7	\$29.5	\$35.8	\$45.2
Average loan size	\$136	\$150	\$131	\$135
Unique users (millions)	–	–	48.0	53.6
Loans per user per year	–	–	5.7	6.3
Annual \$ per user	–	–	\$745	\$848
Loans charged off	–	–	2.63%	1.83%
Loans assessed a late fee	–	–	5.2%	4.1%

Source: CFPB BNPL Market Report, December 2025, using data from Affirm, Cash App Afterpay, Klarna, PayPal, Sezzle and Zip; these six firms represent an estimated 40% of the US point-of-sale financing market in 2023. Dollar figures inflation-adjusted to 2024 CPI-U. 2019–2021 user figures are not reported because only quarterly user data was collected for those years, which would overstate annual user counts. [6]

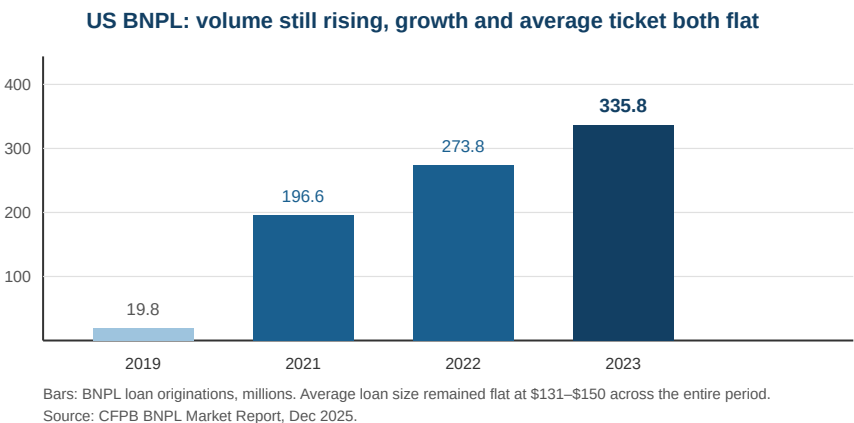


Figure 4. US BNPL loan originations, 2019–2023. Source: CFPB [6].

6.2 Interpretation: the growth is in frequency, not in ticket size

Two features of the CFPB data deserve more attention than they usually receive. First, **the average loan size never moved** — \$136 in 2019, \$150 in 2021, \$131 in 2022, \$135 in 2023 [6]. Second, the growth came from **frequency**: loans per user rose 11% and annual spend per user rose 14% between 2022 and 2023 [6]. BNPL is not being adopted for larger purchases; it is being adopted as a routine substitute for the credit card at the same price point.

Risk quality improved over the same period, with charge-offs falling from 2.63% to 1.83% and late-fee incidence falling from 5.2% to 4.1% [6], which CFPB attributes partly to tighter underwriting and partly to product diversification. The commercial read is that BNPL is a low-friction but low-ticket method, suited to conversion optimisation at the point of decision rather than to basket-building.

7. Post-Pandemic Return Patterns

7.1 What the data shows

The NRF and Happy Returns 2025 Retail Returns Landscape provides the current US baseline [3]:

- Total US retail returns are projected to reach **\$849.9 billion in 2025**.
- An estimated **19.3% of online sales** will be returned in 2025, against an all-channel retail return rate of 15.8%.
- **82% of consumers** say free returns are an important consideration when shopping online.
- **9% of all returns are fraudulent**.
- **45% of shoppers** say it is acceptable to "bend the rules" when returning items.

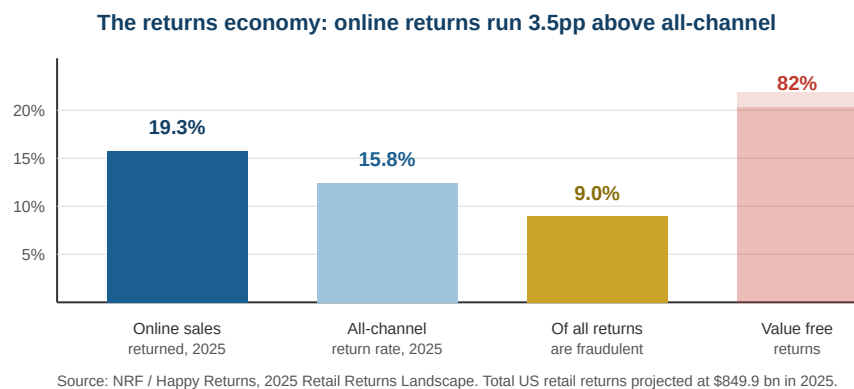


Figure 5. US returns metrics, 2025. Source: NRF / Happy Returns [3]. The 82% free-returns figure is a consumer-preference share and is shown on a separate scale, shaded to indicate it is not directly comparable to the return-rate bars.

7.2 Interpretation: returns became a pricing decision

Two conclusions follow directly from the NRF data. First, **the online return rate of 19.3% against an all-channel 15.8% [3] is a 3.5-percentage-point structural penalty of the online channel**. For merchants with thin gross margins, that gap alone determines whether a category can be sold online profitably, and it must be priced into the product rather than absorbed as a service cost.

Second, the combination of 82% consumer preference for free returns, 9% return fraud and 45% of shoppers admitting they will bend the rules [3] means returns policy is now simultaneously a conversion lever, a fraud surface and a margin decision. The merchants best positioned are those that treat these as three separate problems with three separate controls, rather than as a single customer-service function.

8. Cross-Regional Comparison

8.1 Regional profiles

The four regions examined here differ along structural dimensions rather than in degree. Reading them as a single global growth curve understates the differences that matter commercially.

Dimension	North America	Europe	Southeast Asia	Latin America
Leading reported 2024–25 growth	Mature; mobile at 57% of sales globally [1]	Mature; strongest regulatory and returns discipline	Platform GMV \$128.4 bn, +12% YoY [5]	Retail e-comm \$191.25 bn, +12.2% in 2025 [4]
Discovery channel	Social + search, mature	Search-led, consent-constrained	Live and video commerce = 20% of platform GMV [5]	Marketplace-led, social rising
Payment signature	BNPL at 1% of card volume; 335.8 m BNPL loans 2023 [6]	Digital wallets and regulated credit	Mobile wallets and COD-to-wallet transition	Instant domestic rails (Brazil Pix) anchor volume
Return behaviour	19.3% online return rate; \$849.9 bn total returns 2025 [3]	Strong consumer-return rights; higher structural return norms	Returns emerging; COD legacy friction	Rising; platform-dependent
Platform concentration	Amazon-led, plus Walmart Marketplace	Fragmented; strong marketplace mix	Shopee 52%; top 3 = 84% [5]	Mercado Libre dominant; Brazil and Mexico = 75.2% of net new sales [13]
Primary merchant constraint	Return economics and ad cost	Regulatory compliance and returns	Marketplace dependency and logistics cost	Payments infrastructure and FX volatility

8.2 The concentration finding

Two concentration facts dominate the regional picture and are underweighted in most commentary. In Southeast Asia, Shopee alone holds 52% regional share, with the top three platforms at 84% [5]. In Latin America, Brazil and Mexico together account for 75.2% of net new e-commerce sales [13].

The practical consequence is that merchant strategy in these regions is largely marketplace strategy, because marketplace access is where demand is. This is a materially different position from North America, where merchants retain more direct customer relationships and where the binding constraints are advertising cost and return economics rather than platform access.

9. Key Takeaways: Five Non-Obvious Insights

Insight 1 — Social commerce growth is decelerating while absolute volume compounds, which changes the strategic question from "should we sell on social" to "at what margin."

Social commerce annual growth falls from 67.0% in 2019 to 8.8% by 2028 [11], while absolute sales rise from \$81.9 bn to a projected \$1,085 bn. A 13.3× increase in absolute volume accompanied by an 8.7× reduction in growth rate is the profile of a channel moving from land-grab to margin discipline. Merchants entering on the 2024 growth narrative are arriving one cycle after the arbitrage closed.

Insight 2 — The sustainability premium is a constraint on pricing power, not an opportunity to raise prices.

With 80% of consumers willing to pay more but the average stated premium at only 9.7% [2], and 31% simultaneously naming inflation as their primary risk [2], the addressable market for premium-priced sustainable goods is narrower than the willingness statistic implies. The 9.7% figure is effectively a ceiling on how much a merchant can charge for sustainability claims, not evidence that a premium can be realised. Merchants pricing above this threshold are selling to a small committed minority, and should treat sustainability as a brand-efficiency lever (willingness to pay at parity, preference for credible brands) rather than as a pricing mechanism.

Insight 3 — The online return penalty is now large enough to be a category-selection variable rather than a customer-service variable.

At 19.3% online against 15.8% all-channel [3], online selling carries a 3.5-point structural cost premium. For a category with 40% gross margin and 20% of revenue returned, the return-related cost of goods alone can exceed the entire gross margin on returned units. This means category selection and pricing must be evaluated net of online return exposure, and the 9% fraud rate [3] means the effective exposure is higher still. Merchants choosing categories without reference to return behaviour are optimising the wrong variable.

Insight 4 — BNPL is a conversion tool for existing price points, not a basket-building tool, and its risk profile improved rather than deteriorated.

The average BNPL loan was \$135 in 2023, statistically unchanged from \$136 in 2019 [6], while loans per user rose 11% and annual spend per user rose 14% [6]. Simultaneously charge-offs fell to 1.83% and late-fee incidence to 4.1% [6]. The common merchant fear that BNPL degrades payment performance is not supported by this dataset for the pay-in-four product. Its function is reducing friction at a fixed price point, which makes it most valuable on high-consideration low-ticket items where card friction is the binding constraint — and correspondingly least valuable as a mechanism for increasing average order value.

Insight 5 — The fastest-growing region is the one where merchants have the least direct customer access, which inverts the usual entry logic.

Latin America is projected as the fastest-growing region at 12.2% in 2025 to \$191.25 bn [4], and Southeast Asia is compounding at 12% with 84% of platform share held by three operators [5]. Growth of this magnitude normally signals opportunity, but in both regions access is intermediated: Brazil and Mexico account for 75.2% of Latin American net new sales [13], and Southeast Asian platform GMV is concentrated in three marketplaces [5]. The regions with the fastest growth are those where a new entrant has the least negotiating position. Growth rate and merchant control are inversely related across this dataset, so expansion priority should be set by control economics rather than growth headline.

10. Limitations

1. **Scope inconsistency across sources.** Published "e-commerce" figures are not comparable without checking scope. Some vendors count platform marketplace GMV only, others include brand-direct sites, social platforms and messaging commerce, and others include travel and food delivery. This report avoids aggregating incompatible figures, but where a single global total is needed, the choice of vendor materially changes the answer. Southeast Asia illustrates the spread: platform GMV alone is \$128.4 bn, while total e-commerce GMV including non-platform channels is \$145.2 bn [5].
2. **Forecast status of a significant share of the data.** Bars for 2025 and later in Figures 1 and 2 are estimates or projections, not reported actuals. The social commerce series from 2025 onward [11] and the mobile share projection to 2028 [10] are modelled. They are labelled in-figure so they are not mistaken for observations.
3. **Geographic coverage is uneven.** North American and European data in this report is predominantly US-based, because the highest-quality datasets for payments and returns (CFPB, NRF) are US-only. Statements about "North America" and "Europe" should be read as substantially US- and EU-retailer-behaviour respectively, not as region-wide population statistics.
4. **BNPL user counts are likely overstated.** The CFPB notes its 53.6 million 2023 user figure is likely overstated because the underlying data is aggregate and cannot detect consumers who borrowed from more than one lender in the sample [6]. A Federal Reserve survey separately estimated 15% of US adults, or over 38 million people, used BNPL at least once in 2024 [14].
5. **The BNPL sample covers roughly 40% of the market.** The six CFPB-reporting firms represent an estimated 40% of US point-of-sale financing in 2023, and the sample is explicitly stated as not necessarily representative of the entire BNPL market [6].
6. **Stated preference is not revealed behaviour.** The sustainability findings rest on survey self-report. PwC itself notes the 9.7% stated premium may not translate into actual spend given inflation and cost-of-living pressure [2]. No purchasing-behaviour validation dataset was available to test this gap.
7. **Survey vintage.** The principal sustainability dataset is the 2024 survey [2] and the Simon-Kucher study covers six countries only (US, Germany, UK, Australia, Netherlands, Indonesia) [7]. Neither is a 2025 read, and neither covers Latin America in depth.
8. **Brand-level GMV is not separately identified for most regions.** Momentum Works notes brands contributed under 30% of Southeast Asian platform GMV against over 50% in China [5], but equivalent brand-direct splits are not published for the other regions examined.

11. Sources

All sources below were verified as accessible at the time of compilation.

1. Red Stag Fulfillment — *What Percentage of Ecommerce Sales Happen on Mobile Devices?* Mobile devices account for 57% of global e-commerce sales in 2024 and an estimated 59% in 2025. <https://redstagfulfillment.com/what-percentage-of-ecommerce-sales-on-mobile-devices/>
2. PwC — *PwC 2024 Voice of the Consumer Survey* (n>20,000, 31 countries). 9.7% average sustainability premium; 80% willing to pay more; 46% purchased via social media, up from 21% in 2019; 31% cite inflation as top risk; 83% cite data protection. <https://www.pwc.com/gx/en/news-room/press-releases/2024/pwc-2024-voice-of-consumer-survey.html>
3. National Retail Federation and Happy Returns — *2025 Retail Returns Landscape*. \$849.9 bn total US retail returns 2025; 19.3% online return rate; 82% value free returns; 9% of returns fraudulent; 45% say bending rules is acceptable. <https://nrf.com/research/2025-retail-returns-landscape>
4. eMarketer — *Latin America e-commerce*. Latin America retail e-commerce to grow 12.2% in 2025 to \$191.25 bn, the fastest-growing region worldwide; Argentina, Brazil and Mexico account for 84.5% of sales. <https://www.emarketer.com/topics/category/latin%20america%20ecommerce>
5. Momentum Works — *Ecommerce in Southeast Asia 3.0*. Platform GMV \$128.4 bn in 2024 (+12% YoY); total e-commerce GMV \$145.2 bn; Shopee 52% share, top 3 = 84%; Thailand +21.7%, Malaysia +19.5%, Indonesia 44% share at +5%; live commerce \$17.6 bn and live + video = 20% of platform GMV; brands under 30% of platform GMV; 43.6 m parcels/day. <https://thelowdown.momentum.asia/press-release-southeast-asias-platform-ecommerce-gmv-reaches-us128-4b-top-3-platforms-increase-market-share-to-84-momentum-works/>
6. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau — *BNPL Market Report*, December 2025. Data from Affirm, Cash App Afterpay, Klarna, PayPal, Sezzle and Zip (~40% of US POS financing). 335.8 m loans / \$45.2 bn in 2023; avg loan \$135; 53.6 m users (+12%); 6.3 loans and \$848 per user; charge-offs 1.83%; late fees 4.1%. https://files.consumerfinance.gov/f/documents/cfbp_bnpl-market-report_2025-12.pdf
7. Simon-Kucher — *Sustainability 2024: Navigating Consumer Behavior* (n=6,120, six countries). https://www.simon-kucher.com/sites/default/files/perspectives-files/Brochure_2024_Sustainability_Study_compressed.pdf
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9. TechRT — *Mobile Commerce Statistics*. Mobile commerce to exceed \$3 trillion by 2027; 9–11% annual growth 2026–2028. <https://techrt.com/mobile-commerce-statistics/>
10. DemandSage — *Mobile Commerce Statistics 2026*. Mobile share 57% of global e-commerce revenue in 2024, projected 63% by 2028. <https://www.demandsage.com/mobile-commerce-statistics/>
11. Oberlo — *Social Commerce Market Size (2018–2028)*. Full annual series with year-over-year change; \$699.4 bn in 2024 (+22.6%); 19.4% of global e-commerce in 2024 to 21.7% by 2028; \$1,085 bn projected 2028. <https://www.oberlo.com/statistics/social-commerce-market-size>
12. PixelPanda — *Social Commerce Statistics 2024–2025*. US social commerce \$71.62 bn in 2024 (+26% YoY, eMarketer); TikTok Shop global GMV \$33.2 bn in 2024, +201% YoY (Momentum Works); 100.7 m Americans bought via social media in 2024. <https://pixelpanda.ai/statistics/social-commerce-statistics>
13. eMarketer — *Latin America Ecommerce Forecast 2024*. Brazil and Mexico to drive the bulk of net new Latin American e-commerce sales, with a combined regional share of 75.2%. <https://www.emarketer.com/content/latin-america-ecommerce-forecast-2024>
14. Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System — *Economic Well-Being of U.S. Households in 2024*. 15% of US adults, or over 38 million people, used BNPL at least once in 2024. <https://www.federalreserve.gov/publications/files/2024-report-economic-well-being-us-households-202505.pdf>

Prepared to inform commercial strategy. Third-party figures reflect each source's stated scope, methodology and vintage; scope differences are discussed in Sections 2.2 and 10. Projections and estimates are labelled as such throughout and should not be read as observations. No warranty is given as to the completeness or accuracy of third-party data.